

green energy can only be a supplementary power source. Taking the forefront in the energy race is out of the question.

Government apathy

Now this is where the finger pointing starts. Most world governments have participated in various UNFCCC (United Nations Framework on Climate Change) summits, signed the Kyoto protocol and promised to bring down greenhouse gas emissions by at least 18%. At the same time, those very same governments have invested hundreds of billions of dollars into the hunt for sources of fossil fuels. As you must have understood from the first story, global warming is directly related to the CO₂ that we produce and burning said fossil fuels will produce CO₂. If any world government has any hope of achieving those environmental targets, it must, under all circumstances, stop harvesting more fossil fuels right now; literally right now. Even if the world governments decide to use only 50% of what they have currently stockpiled, global temperatures can rise by a catastrophic 4C which will send the world into one of the most severe global food shortages ever.

Four degrees might not seem like much on a global scale, but that can be the difference between solid ice and liquid water; It's the difference between wheat fields and barren grasslands. The difference is only 4C but the impact, tremendous. The world governments are in the extremely unenviable position of having to choose between satisfying their country's desperate need for power and saving the planet by sacrificing their citizen's luxuries. Either way, this is a very bold decision, politically speaking, and one that any government will hesitate to take. Regardless, no government will

willingly sacrifice all that power just like that. And anyway, if there is rationing, who decides how much fuel is burnt by whom? The Chinese will say that the whole world's economy is dependent on their production and they need more oil. The U.S. will not want to sacrifice its stranglehold on the world in general and India will say that it's a developing nation and needs all the power it can get to pull its people up from poverty. Countries with no say might not get anything. Oil is power and the distribution of that oil will determine the distribution of power.



Can you sacrifice this for the environment?

Human apathy

We also take the "trouble" to criticize the government's decision, whatever it may be, good or bad. Unfortunately, we love our comforts as much as the next man and it's hard for us to look beyond ourselves, especially when it comes to things that we've taken for granted or think we've tried so hard to achieve. Would you be willing to sacrifice that comfort so that China can run a factory for a few more hours or an American marine can be returned home from Iraq? Forget global politics, would you be willing to sacrifice all that so that your politicians can get to that "emergency" meeting in their helicopter? Would you be willing to sacrifice all that freedom that cheap (yes, it's cheap, very cheap) power gives you for

the promise of reduced temperatures and a more sustainable ecosystem some 100 years in the future?

The carbon-bubble

Aren't we all just waiting for that miracle solution that will just clear up the whole situation at the snap of a finger while we wallow in the irresponsibility that we love so much? It's not just our apathy in general; most of the capital that those oil companies are investing in their oil surveys (the oil kind, not online) is not just coming from governments. Many of those funds that people have invested in, are not just investing in Apple and IBM; they've got billions of dollars invested in oil and coal, hundreds of billions. These financial institutions are placing their bets based on one very important factor, the fact that they believe that governments will succumb to the need for power and just completely ignore the environment.

Conclusion

Will we just fall back to our innate fatalism and natural resilience as a species? People do live in the heart of Africa and in the depths of the Antarctic after all. But, as a species capable of thought and creativity, it's shameful that we won't even try to do something about our (continued) existence. Didn't intelligence evolve to ensure our survival? Are we so dumb that we will just squander that so-called intelligence on pure self-indulgence? As a geek at heart, doesn't that sting at the very soul of what it is to be a geek? If things continue to spiral downwards the way they are now, green tech is doomed. Can we save it? Yes, but it will take a monumental effort and great sacrifice; an effort that might be without a tangible reward in this life time. Are we willing to make that sacrifice? **d**



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